

need to recognize two definitions of ‘lost’: 1) lost beyond recovery, at least by objective means; 2) lost from view, in the sense that the available evidence has not been sufficiently studied to permit an empirical choice between/among competing variants. I consider that my *Identity IV* provides more than enough evidence to demonstrate that the first definition is false. The Hortian theory and all derivatives thereof, such as eclecticism (of whatever type), is not science, and may not honestly be called science. The second definition allows for scientific procedure. I suggest and recommend that we start using the term ‘manuscriptology’, rather than ‘textual criticism’—manuscriptology refers to the study of the MSS, and is neutral as to presupposition. Any scientific exercise should begin with the evidence; so what is the evidence?

The primary evidence is furnished by the continuous text manuscripts (Greek) of the NT. The evidence furnished by the lectionaries is secondary. The evidence furnished by ancient versions and patristic citations is tertiary. Genuine historical evidence (to the extent that this can be determined) is ancillary. Where the primary evidence is unequivocal, the remaining types should not come into play. For example, at any given point in the four Gospels there will be around 1,700 extant continuous text MSS, representing all lines of transmission and all locales.¹ Where they all agree, there can be no legitimate doubt as to the original wording. But what if an early Papyrus comes to light with a variant, does that change the picture? The very fact of being early suggests that it is bad; why wasn’t it used and worn out?

We have probably all heard/read the canard, ‘manuscripts are to be weighed, not counted’. The basic meaning of the verb ‘to weigh’ refers to an objective procedure; it is done with physically verifiable weights. But do the followers of Hort (who are the main ones who keep repeating it) ‘weigh’ manuscripts using objective criteria? They do not, which is why I call it a ‘canard’. That said, however, I submit for the consideration of all concerned that it is indeed possible to weigh MSS using objective criteria.

Just how are MSS to be weighed? And who might be competent to do the weighing? As the reader is by now well aware, Hort and most subsequent scholars have done their ‘weighing’ on the basis of so-called ‘internal evidence’—the two standard criteria are, ‘choose the reading which fits the context’ and ‘choose the reading which explains the origin of the other reading’.

¹ Of course we know that there are many MSS not yet ‘extant’, not yet identified and catalogued, so the number can only go up.